

How Telegram Accounts Get Faked

What every Telegram user on iPhone or Android needs to know

THE CORE PROBLEM

On most platforms, pretending to be someone else is hard. On Telegram, it is surprisingly easy — not because someone broke in, but because of how Telegram was designed.

Think of it like a conference where anyone can write any name on their badge and attach any photo. Nobody checks ID at the door. If two people wear the exact same badge, no alarm goes off. The only reliable proof of identity — a wristband number assigned when you entered — is locked in a back office you never visit.

That wristband number is Telegram's internal account ID. It is the only thing that cannot be faked. But Telegram does not show it to you anywhere in the normal app.

WHY FAKING AN ACCOUNT IS EASY

1. Anyone can copy your name exactly

Telegram does **not require display names to be unique**. An impersonator can create an account with a name that is letter-for-letter identical to yours, download your profile photo (if it is public), and message your contacts. Telegram will not

warn those contacts that a new account suddenly shares your exact name and photo.

2. Usernames can use invisible lookalike letters

Your username *is* unique — but only in the exact characters used. A scammer can register a username that looks identical by swapping one letter for a lookalike from another alphabet. For example, a Cyrillic "a" and a Latin "a" appear the same on screen but are different characters. This makes @support and what looks like @support actually two completely different accounts.

3. Usernames can be re-claimed after someone gives them up

If a trusted person or company gives up their Telegram username, anyone else can claim it immediately. A scammer who grabs it then inherits all the trust people associated with that name.

4. Verification is not available to ordinary people

Telegram's blue verification badge is reserved for large, active official channels and organisations. **Regular user accounts cannot get one.** A system for third-party verification was introduced in January 2025, but it covers only recognised institutional verifiers, not private individuals. [1, 2]

5. Your phone number is hidden from strangers by default

The one piece of information that would let someone distinguish the real you from a fake — your registered phone number — is hidden from people who are not already your contacts. So a stranger contacting your friends sees only a name and photo, both of which can be copied.

HOW BIG IS THIS PROBLEM?

FAKE CHANNELS STUDIED

SUBSCRIBERS ON ONE FAKE

35,382

Telegram channels analysed in a 2021 academic study, covering 130 million messages [3]

364,663

People subscribed to a single fake channel impersonating a named public figure [3]

FAKE ACCOUNTS PER DAY

300+

New impersonator accounts created daily during December 2024, up from ~160 in November [4]

STOLEN IN ONE SCAM WAVE

\$3 M+

Lost by at least two victims deceived by a fake "verification bot" in Telegram in late 2024 [5]

In October 2024, an Indian court (Madras High Court) accepted Telegram's undertaking to remove and block fake channels impersonating a major payments app after thousands of customers were redirected to scammers. [6]

KNOWN SECURITY FLAWS THAT MADE THINGS WORSE

Beyond the design issues above, security researchers have found specific technical flaws in the Telegram apps:

FLAW	PLATFORM	WHAT IT DID	STATUS
Disguised malware files CVE-2024-7014, ESET Research	ANDROID	Attackers could send a malicious app disguised as a video thumbnail. Tapping "play" prompted you to install malware. Sold on criminal forums before Telegram fixed it.	Fixed July 2024
Lookalike web links CVE-2019-10044 & CVE-2020-12474	IOS & ANDROID	Links inside Telegram messages could display a trusted web address (e.g. your bank's site) while actually pointing somewhere else. Patched, but	Fixed 2019 & 2020

FLAW	PLATFORM	WHAT IT DID	STATUS
		two separate patches were needed.	
IP address leak	IOS & ANDROID	Tapping a Telegram "proxy" link immediately revealed your real IP address to the link sender, before any confirmation dialog appeared.	Patched
Reversed filename trick Kaspersky, 2018	WINDOWS ONLY	A hidden character could make a virus file display as an image. Exploited for almost a year before discovery.	Fixed 2018

IPHONE VS ANDROID: ONE EXTRA RISK FOR IPHONE USERS

iPhone only: Even if you set "Who can add me to groups" to "Nobody" in Telegram's privacy settings, Telegram Premium subscribers can still add you to groups against your wishes. This loophole does not exist on Android. It means a scammer with a Premium account can silently place you into a fake "support" or "investment" group without your consent. [7]

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

- ✓ **Verify identity outside Telegram.** If someone contacts you claiming to be a friend, colleague, or company representative, call them or check through a different channel before acting on any request — especially requests involving money or passwords.

- ✓ **Turn on two-step verification.** Go to Settings → Privacy and Security → Two-Step Verification. This prevents someone from taking over your account if your phone number is ever recycled by your carrier.

- ✓ **Check usernames character by character.** Look for subtle differences: a "1" instead of "l", a capital "I" instead of a lowercase "l", or a zero instead of "O". These are designed to be invisible at a glance.

- ✓ **Keep the Telegram app updated.** Several of the flaws above required app updates to fix. Running an old version leaves you exposed to known attacks.

- ✓ **Be cautious about groups you did not join yourself.** If you find yourself in an unfamiliar group — especially one that immediately offers investment tips, prizes, or urgent help — leave it. On iPhone, check your privacy settings even if you set them to "Nobody."

- ✓ **Treat urgent financial requests in Telegram as a red flag.** Legitimate organisations do not ask for transfers, cryptocurrency, or login codes through Telegram messages.

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